MOREH NEVUCHIM

What Are Demons? Gender in Torah, Adam & the Shedim

Given Tuesday 16 June 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim §1 · Ch 6–7

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** 1 · Chapter 6 (completed) & Chapter 7 **Topic:** Ish & Isha — Is God Male or Female? · Yalad and the Power of a Teacher · Shedim Reinterpreted **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Recap — The Arc of Section 1 So Far

Chapters	Theme
1–2	Tzelem Elokim; Adam before and after the sin (emet/sheker → tov/ra)
3	*Temunah* vs. *Tavnit* — images of God
4	The verbs of seeing God — sight vs. insight
5	Caution in ascending to the divine; the burning bush (four readings); Moshe vs. the nobles
6 (begun last week)	*Ish* & *Isha* — terms borrowed for male/female creatures, then for anything that attaches/receives. **Ish = Tzura (form); Isha = Chomer (matter).** All existence is the union of form and matter

Recap of Chapter 6's Core (Last Week)

- *Ish/Isha* primarily = human male/female; borrowed for animals (מכל הבהמה... איש ואשתו = simply male and female); then *isha* borrowed for **anything designated to attach/receive** (the Mishkan curtains: חוברות אשה אל אחותה)
- **Ish = Tzura (form, the affector/mashpia); Isha = Chomer (matter, the affected/nishpa)**
- Per Yesodei HaTorah: nothing exists as form-alone or matter-alone — all existence is their union

  לזאת יקרא אשה כי מאיש לוקחה — the woman as receptacle/manifester of the man
- Implications: equal but different (egalitarianism-as-sameness is un-Torah); marriage as completion (לבשר אחד; one without a spouse lacks *shalom* = *shleimut*, completeness)

PART 1 — Completing Chapter 6: Is God Male or Female?

The Verse — "Hashem Ish Milchamah"

ה' איש מלחמה, ה' שמו "*Hashem is a man of war, Hashem is His name*" (Shirat HaYam)

Obviously not a physical man. So what does it mean that Hashem is a "man of war"?

Why God Is Usually Referred to in the Masculine

Hakadosh Baruch Hu is **primarily the משפיע (affector/influencer/giver)**, rather than the affected.

That is why Hashem is normally referred to in the **masculine** — He is the mashpia, the affector.

What About the Feminine References to God?

We Sefardim say **נקדישך ונעריצך** (feminine: "we will sanctify You"); many liturgical references are feminine. Does this mean Hashem is affected by us?

Absolutely not. Anything that is *affected* is *incomplete* — which would contradict God being *shalem* (complete and unchanging).

When we refer to Hashem in the feminine, we are NOT referring to God Himself, but to **a manifestation** — the **Shechinah**, etc. God Himself is never feminine, because He cannot be affected.

In essence, God is neither masculine nor feminine — but insofar as we assign Him a gender, it is masculine, because He is primarily the affector.

The Kli Yakar (Rabbi Shlomo Laniado, ~500 years ago)

(Brought via Rabbi Daniel Korobkin's Moreh shiurim.)

On the last verse of Bereishit Chapter 1 — and the question: **Why do we begin Friday-night Kiddush with "Yom HaShishi" before "Vayechulu"?**

The Hidden Name

The phrase **יום הששי ויכלו השמים** — the final letters spell:

יום הששי ויכלו השמים → **י-ה-ו-ה** (the four-letter Name)

וכפי הפשט חתם על מעשה בראשית בשם של י-ה המשותף בין איש לאשה *"He sealed the creation with the Name Y-H, which is shared between ish and isha."*

The Yud and the Hei

The Gemara (Bava Batra): everything Hashem created is male or female (זכר ונקבה בראם). Hence Hebrew — unlike English — assigns gender to everything, even inanimate objects.

Letter	Gender	In the words	Names of God
Yud (י)	**Masculine** — the affector	(Aleph-Yud-Shin) **אִישׁ** carries the **Yud**	Masculine Names begin with **Aleph** (the beginning/affector): Adon-ai, Elok-im, Kel
Hei (ה)	**Feminine** — the affected	(Aleph-Shin-Hei) **אִשָּׁה** carries the **Hei**	Feminine Names (Shechinah, Shakkai, Shabbat) relate to the end of the alphabet (the Shin/affected)

(This is Rabbi Tatz's framework: Yud = masculine, Hei = feminine.)

The Kli Yakar's Point

כי כל זכר דמיון למשפיע, וכל נקבה דמיון למושפע *"Every male resembles the affector; every female resembles the affected."*

Everything in the universe contains an affecting side and an affected side. In the creation of a child: the man gives the *zera* (the tzura — the conceptual/theoretical), and the woman **receives** it and over nine months develops the *chomer* (the matter).

הקדוש ברוך הוא המשפיע הראשון... אבל הוא יתברך אינו מושפע מזולתו *"Hashem is the first affector... but He Himself is never affected by another."*

The Kli Yakar holds God is innately masculine — always referred to as "He" — because He is the eternal mashpia, never affected. (Feminine references = manifestations like the Shechinah, not God Himself.)

The master point: the universe is binary — male or female, affector or affected. There is no non-binary. This is why creation is "sealed" with Y-H: existence is *complete* only when it is both male and female. (The Vav-Hei of the Name, the Kli Yakar adds, relate to the future/Olam Haba — beyond our scope here.)

Closing Chapter 6 — Ach and Achot Too

הרי התבאר לך שגם **אחות ואח** הם רב-משמעיים על דרך ההשאלה כמו איש ואשה *Brother and sister are likewise multi-meaning, borrowed terms.*

- **Achot** — from the Mishkan curtains (חוברות אשה אל אחותה — "each to her sister")
- **Ach** — likely from the Keruvim: **ופניהם איש אל אחיו** ("their faces, each man to his brother") — denoting their character as *mashpiim* (affectors), facing one another

Just as *ish/isha* are metaphorical and multi-meaning, so are *ach/achot*.

Why Is This Chapter Here? (The Placement Question)

The first five chapters dealt with **incorporeality**. Chapter 6 seems to digress. Why?

The Narboni's Answer

It continues the incorporeality theme **because of ה' איש מלחמה** — Rambam wants to clarify that "man of war" doesn't mean God is a male, but that He is the **mashpia (affector)** — a borrowed term, not an anthropomorphism.

The Simpler/Preferred Answer

Rambam told us in his introduction he would also explain **Ma'aseh Bereshit** (the workings of creation/physics). Just as Chapters 1–2 covered both incorporeality *and* the creation narrative (Adam's sin), **ish and isha are central to the creation narrative** — what marriage is, the binary structure of existence. This is Ma'aseh Bereshit: understanding the physics of the world Hashem created.

Chapter 6 Summary

Ish/Isha are borrowed for male/female creatures and, crucially, for **anything that attaches** — *ish* the affector, *isha* the receptacle. All existence reduces to ish/isha = tzura/chomer. From this:

the bond of marriage, the binary universe, why God is usually masculine (the affector), and that *ach/achot* are likewise metaphorical terms.

PART 2 — Chapter 7: Yalad, the Power of a Teacher, and Shedim

This chapter continues from Chapter 6: a man and woman unite — **what is the product?** And it ties directly into Rambam's halachic works.

The Five Meanings of יָלַד (Yalad — "to give birth")

#	Meaning	Proof Text
1	**Literal birth** — offspring of man and woman	וילדו לו בנים (Ki Tetzei)
2	**Creation of natural phenomena**	בטרם הרים יולדו — "before the mountains were born" (Tehillim)
3	**The earth sprouting** (rain causing growth)	הגשם... הולידה והצמיחה — rain "gave birth to" the earth (Yeshayahu)
4	**New events occurring**	כי לא תדע מה ילד יום — "you don't know what the day will birth" (Mishlei)
5	**Birthing new ideas / views — being taught**	יחבל און... וילד שקר — conceiving and "birthing" falsehood (Tehillim); ובילדי נכרים יספיקו — adopting the ideas of the nations (Yeshayahu, per Yonatan ben Uziel)

The Power of a Teacher — Meaning 5 in Depth

מי שלימד אדם דבר מה והקנה לו דעה, הוא כאילו הוליד את האיש ההוא — One who teaches a person and imparts knowledge to him — it is as if he gave birth to that person.

This is why the disciples of prophets are called **בני הנביאים** (the "sons of the prophets") — not biological sons, but students.

The Gemara (Sanhedrin 19b)

כל המלמד את בן חברו תורה, מעלה עליו הכתוב כאילו ילדו — *One who teaches another's child Torah Scripture credits him as if he birthed the child.*

Proof: Bamidbar opens **ואלה תולדות אהרן ומשה** ("these are the offspring of Aharon and Moshe") — yet then lists only **the sons of Aharon** (Nadav, Avihu, Elazar, Itamar). Why are they called Moshe's offspring too?

אהרן ילד, ומשה לימד — לפיכך נקראו על שמו — *Aharon birthed them; Moshe taught them — therefore they bear his name too.*

Illuminating the Verse in Toldot

ואלה תולדות יצחק בן אברהם — אברהם הוליד את יצחק

The apparent redundancy is resolved: Yitzchak was Avraham's son **both physically and intellectually** — Avraham birthed him *and* taught him his Torah and worldview.

The Halachic Payoff — Saving Your Teacher Before Your Parent

The Mishnah (end of Bava Metzia Ch. 2): if your **parent** and your **rav** are both drowning and you can save only one — **you save your rav first.**

The Qualification (Gemara)

This applies only to your **rabo muvhak** — your primary teacher from whom you learned **the majority** of your Torah and intellect. *(Rare today: in earlier times one teacher took a student from alef-bet all the way up. Now we pass through many teachers, so a true rabo muvhak is uncommon.)*

Why This Makes Sense (via the Rambam)

A **rabo muvhak gave birth to you** — just as your parent did. Your parent birthed you into a life of 120 years; your teacher birthed you into **Olam Haba — infinite time.** So the teacher's "birthing" has the longer-lasting effect.

The Further Halacha

If your **father** also taught you Torah (even not the majority), you save **him** first — because he birthed you *both physically and (partly) spiritually*. Only when the father taught little, and the rabo muvhak gave you the majority of your Torah, do you save the rav first.

This is also the foundation of the *premium on kavod* for teachers and elders (מפני שיבה תקום והדרת פני זקן; אפילו לימדו אות אחת חייב לכבדו) — they are, in a sense, one's parents.

The Cryptic Cross-Reference — "When We Discuss *Ben*"

Rambam says he'll explain more "when we discuss the term *ben* (son)" — but **he never does** (Rav Kapach notes this).

Rav Makbili's Beautiful Suggestion

Notice: for *literal* birth (meaning 1), Rambam cited a late verse (Ki Tetzei: וילדו לו בנים) — skipping the obvious earlier one in the creation narrative itself:

> **בעצב תלדי בנים** *"In pain you shall bear children"* (Bereishit 3, the consequence to Chava)

Why skip it? **Deliberately** — so that we connect the dots ourselves: *be'etzev teldi banim* is not only a curse but a **reality** — that with hard work (etzev), one can "birth" ideas and concepts in those who come after, and they become one's *banim*. Through toil, a person births many "children" far beyond biological offspring — by teaching.

The Climax — Adam, Shet, and the Meaning of Shedim

The Verse

> **ויחי אדם שלושים ומאת שנה, ויולד בדמותו כצלמו, ויקרא את שמו שת** *Adam lived 130 years, and birthed in his likeness and image, and called him Shet.*

Rambam's Reading

For Adam's first 130 years (after the sin), his children **did not attain the true human form** — they lacked the full **tzelem and demut** (the intellectual form, per Chapters 1–2). Only **Shet** — whom Adam **taught and gave understanding** — attained human completeness. Hence specifically of Shet: *birthed in his likeness and image.*

- Adam needed 130 years to do **teshuvah** and develop himself enough to transmit *tzelem Elokim* properly to a descendant
- **Shet** = from *yashat/shitah* — **foundation**; he is the next *foundation* of the world after Adam and Chava, because the world is founded on those with correct intellect *(Rav Nebenzahl)*
- *(Rabbi Korobkin suggests this could even engage the evolution question — the pre-Shet "incomplete humans" as a separate matter; a discussion for elsewhere.)*

The Final Paragraph — Worse Than an Animal

> **כל מי שלא השיג אותה הצורה... אינו אדם, אלא בעל חיים בעל תבנית אדם ותארו** One who has not attained that [intellectual] form **is not a human — but an animal in the figure (tavnit) of a human.**

And in fact **worse than an animal**:

> כי כוח המחשבה ושיקול הדעת... משתמש בהם לצורך תחבולות הגורמות לרעות ולנזקים Because the intellect meant for perfection is used instead **for schemes that cause harm** — a capacity no animal has.

> והרי הוא **כדבר הדומה לאדם המחקה אותו** *He is like something resembling a human, imitating one* — not truly human.

This explains human criminality and immorality, which we don't find among animals: humans can turn their intellect to destructive ends.

The Gemara (Eruvin 18b) — Reinterpreted

> כל אותן השנים שהיה אדם הראשון בנידוי, הוליד רוחין ושדין ולילין *All the years Adam was "excommunicated," he birthed spirits, demons, and lilin.*

The Gemara clarifies: during 130 years Adam separated from his wife (a chasid doing teshuvah) — so the "births" were from nocturnal emissions.

Rambam's Figurative Reading — What a Shed Actually Is

Rambam reads this entire Gemara as a metaphor *(against the Kabbalistic literal reading)*:

A **shed (demon) is not a spiritual entity coming to get you.** It is a **sub-human** — a person with the physical figure of a human but undeveloped or corrupted intellect.

For 130 years Adam birthed **sub-humans** — creatures with eyes, mouth, arms, legs, but without realized *tzelem Elokim*. That is what "ruchin, shedin, lilin" means. Only at 130, after true teshuvah, did he birth **Shet** — *bidmuto ketzalmo*.

The Narboni's Sharp Point

Many religious people spend their lives on segulot and incantations to ward off **imperceptible** shedim — and thereby **turn their attention away from the real shedim**: the human beings around us with corrupt characters and bad influence. *Those* are the demons to avoid.

The Sweep of Supporting Sources — Rambam's Consistent Reinterpretation

The Metzora Sits Shiva for Himself (Rav David Fohrman)

The leper is cast out, grows hair, tears clothes, conveys tumah almost like a corpse. Why? When a person dies, the family mourns a vacuum. **The metzora mourns himself** — still physically alive and human in body, but having lost his *tzelem Elokim*, become animal-like. He sits shiva for himself.

"Cursed Is He Who Lies With an Animal" (Pesachim)

said of one who marries the daughter of an *am ha'aretz* — ארור שוכב עם כל בהמה

Not a mere ignoramus — but one who **misused their intellect** and became sub-human (no *tzelem u'demut*). Hence the comparison to an animal.

Min = A New Species (Rav Moshe Shapiro)

We call heretics **minim** — *species* — because such a person is a **new kind of creature**: not human (no tzelem u'demut), yet not a four-legged beast. A human figure that is, in truth, an animal — a new *min*.

Capital Punishment Is Not "Murder"

Once Beit Din issues a guilty verdict deserving capital punishment, the person is **no longer classified with the status of a human** — so executing him is not *Lo Tirtzach*; it is not killing a human.

Rambam on Bava Kamma (Commentary on the Mishnah)

On **שור של ישראל שנגח שור של נכרי — פטור** (a Jew's ox that gores a non-Jew's ox is exempt), Rambam (in his 20s) preempts the moral concern:

> One lacking human moral perfection... אינו בכלל האדם על האמת **is** מי שאין בו שלמות המידות האנושיות **not truly included in "human".**

Here *Yisrael* = one who developed character and bears *tzelem u'demut*; *nochri* = one who did not — a **sub-human**. The exemption is because it's not goring between two full humans. *(Maor's question — is this like Ir Nidachat? Yes — and there one must say that living among a majority so corrupt, one is inevitably influenced, so the whole city bears a degree of that sub-humanity.)*

Rambam's Pattern Across His Writings — Shedim Are Not Literal

Source	The Gemara	Rambam's Reading
Makkot	Hatra'ah valid even **על ידי עד שד** ("from a demon")	Not a demon — being warned **without seeing** the warner (e.g., hearing a voice from the other side of a building); a human then testifies to it. *(Tosafot, by contrast, takes "shed" literally and constructs an okimta.)*
Shabbat (Bameh Madlikin)	Extinguishing a candle **מפני רוח רעה**	*Ruach ra'ah* = **melancholy/depression** (he writes "melancholy" in the Commentary) — the person needs to sleep and can't with the light on
Gittin/Yevamot (agunah)	Testimony of a death valid only if you saw the speaker or his shadow (**בבואה דבבואה**) — lest it be a **shed**	Rambam **omits this qualification entirely** when codifying — because he didn't accept the concept of shedim
Snakebite on Shabbat	One may recite an **incantation** (lachash) on a wound	Rambam: it **doesn't work** — permitted only **psychologically**, to prevent the sufferer's distress

Rambam consistently reinterprets shedim, incantations, and amulets figuratively or psychologically.

The Vilna Gaon's Sharp Objection

The Gra was famously upset with the Rambam here. On Rambam's statement that **כשפים, שמות, לחשים, שדים, וקמיעות — הכל הוא שקר** ("witchcraft, names, incantations, demons, and amulets are all false"):

כבר הכו על קדקדו, שמצינו הרבה מעשה בגמרא [בכשפים]... ופילוסופיה הטתו... לפרש הגמרא בדרך הליצה ולעקרם מפשטם — *The Gra: it was his philosophical leanings that bent him to explain these Gemarot metaphorically and uproot them from their plain meaning.* וחס ושלום, איני מאמין בהם ולא מהם ולא מהמונם — אלא כל הדברים כפשטם, ויש להם פנימיות — *God forbid — I do not [side] with them; rather all these things are literal, and they have an inner meaning"* — not the philosophers' meaning.

So the Gra holds shedim, amulets, and incantations are **literal** (with a deeper layer); Rambam reads them figuratively. *(Some suggest Rambam had a different girsa — but the pattern is clearly deliberate.)*

Tonight's Summary

Chapter 6 (Completed) — Is God Male or Female?

- *Ish milchamah* — God is "masculine" only in the sense of being the **mashpia (affector)**; feminine references point to **manifestations** (Shechinah), never God Himself, who cannot be affected
- **Kli Yakar**: Kiddush's *Yom HaShishi Vayechulu* encodes the Name Y-H-W-H; **Yud = masculine, Hei = feminine**; the universe is **binary** — sealed as "male and female He created them"

- *Ach/Achot* are likewise metaphorical (Keruvim; Mishkan curtains)
- Placement: this is **Ma'aseh Bereshit** — the physics of creation

Chapter 7 — Yalad, Teachers, and Shedim

- **Yalad** = (1) birth, (2) creation of nature, (3) earth sprouting, (4) new events, (5) **birthing ideas — teaching**
- **To teach someone is to give birth to them** (בני הנביאים; Aharon birthed, Moshe taught; אברהם הוליד את יצחק) — grounding the halacha to **save your rabo muvhak before your parent** (he birthed you into infinite time)
- *Be'etzev teldi banim* (cryptic) — with toil, one births "children" through teaching
- **Adam & Shet**: for 130 years Adam birthed sub-humans; only after teshuvah did he birth Shet *bidmuto ketzalmo* — the new **foundation**
- **A shed is a sub-human** — a person in human figure lacking realized *tzelem Elokim*; can be *worse* than an animal by misusing intellect
- The real demons are corrupt people around us (Narboni) — not imperceptible spirits
- Supporting reinterpretations: the metzora mourning himself; *min* = a new species; capital punishment not "murder"; the Bava Kamma ox; and across Makkot, Shabbat, Gittin, snakebite — **Rambam reads shedim/incantations figuratively**, against which the **Vilna Gaon** strongly objected

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Coming Up Next

Continuing the Moreh — the next chapters of Section 1.

(Chodesh Tov — Rosh Chodesh Tammuz.)

B'Ezrat Hashem

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